ence in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for different streams. Indicators critical for establishing the best colleges were meticulously determined, and their relative weights were finalised. For a year-on-year comparison the weightages of parameters have remained unchanged over the last two years.

↘ Comprehensive objective questionnaires were designed for each of the 14 streams, taking into account the chosen performance indicators and were put up in the public domain—on the websites of India Today and MDRA. Our research partner directly contacted about 10,000 colleges that fulfilled the eligibility criteria, seeking objective data for verification. Attested soft copies were sought, and 1,865 eligible colleges submitted institutional data along with voluminous supporting documents within the stipulated deadline.

↘ After receipt of the objective data from participating colleges, MDRA verified the information provided by them. In case of insufficient/incorrect data, respective colleges were asked to provide complete, correct and updated information.

↘ A perceptual survey about these colleges was carried out among 1,854 well-informed respondents (563 senior faculty members, 310 recruiters/professionals, 397 career accelerators and 584 final year students) across 27 cities, divided into four zones.

North: Delhi, Noida, Ghaziabad, Gurugram, Faridabad, Lucknow, Kota, Amritsar, Chandigarh, Ludhiana and Jalandhar

East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati, Patna and Raipur

West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad, Indore, Bhopal and Nagpur

South: Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Kochi and Coimbatore

↘ National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective field of experience and were given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightages, respectively. They also rated the institutes on a 10-point rating scale on each of the five key parameters.

↘ While computing objective scores, it was ensured that aggregate data alone was not used, and hence, data sets were normalised on the basis of the number of students for fair comparison. The total scores arrived at from the objective and perception surveys were added in the ratio of 60:40—for 11 professional courses—while a ratio of 50:50 was taken for academic courses—arts, science and commerce—to get the final combined score.

STREAM	NO. OF PARTICIPATING COLLEGES IN...							
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018
ARTS	196	186	173	172	162	131	121	102
SCIENCE	218	211	198	187	179	145	130	108
COMMERCE	254	229	225	213	202	167	151	121
MEDICAL	54	55	57	53	55	50	50	39
DENTAL	58	62	61	60	59	47	47	46
ENGINEERING	268	284	278	269	249	248	242	220
ARCHITECTURE	54	45	40	42	44	31	31	25
LAW	79	70	72	62	67	49	47	47
MASS COMMUNICATION	60	56	56	47	49	40	39	25
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	82	76	76	71	69	60	51	39
BBA	225	213	201	184	179	147	132	85
BCA	199	169	171	149	146	113	97	75
SOCIAL WORK	54	64	56	56	52	39	36	28
FASHION DESIGN	64	59	51	49	47	35	33	28
TOTAL	1,865	1,779	1,715	1,614	1,559	1,302	1,207	988

New addition: Most Improved colleges

A major highlight of this year's India Today-MDRA Best Colleges Survey is the introduction of a new category—'Most Improved Colleges'—recognising institutions that have made the greatest strides over time. This ranking captures the five-year growth trajectory of colleges across all 14 streams by analysing the change in their relative positions in the annual rankings from 2020 to 2025. It focuses on the percentage improvement in rank, thereby offering a dynamic perspective on institutional performance, rather than a static snapshot.

The college that records the highest percentage rise in rank over the five-year period is placed at the top of this list, followed by others in decreasing order of improvement. This new category is a testament to the transformative efforts made by educational institutions to enhance their standing and quality, and it offers a fresh lens through which aspirants, parents, recruiters and policymakers can assess sustained institutional development.

↘ An experienced and large team of researchers, statisticians and analysts worked on this project. The MDRA core team, led by Abhishek Agrawal (Executive Director), comprised Abnish Jha (Project Director), Vaibhav Gupta (Deputy Research Manager), Robin Singh (Assistant Research Executive), Rishav Sharma (Assistant Research Executive) and Manveer Singh (Assistant Manager EDP). ■